PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Lada Niva (VAZ-2121 / 4x4 Legend)

1977–present · VAZ-2121 · 21213 · 21214 · VAZ-2131

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust is the deal-breaker**
  It's a 1970s Soviet unibody, so the body is the chassis. Probe the sills, the jacking points, the floor where the sills join it, and where the rear trailing-arm brackets mount. NIVA-FAQ's sill guide says to tap with a screwdriver and replace anything you can push it through. Most of the BaT Nivas we read noted rust somewhere: under the bonnet, on the undercarriage or in the rear arches.

- [ ] **Know which Niva you're buying**
  The VIN starts with XTA (AvtoVAZ), then six characters for the model (212100 is a 2121), a model-year character and a seven-digit serial. Pre-1985 trucks have chrome details and a red-background badge; 1.7 trucks from 1993–94 have vertical tail lights and a tailgate that drops to the bumper. A Chevrolet Niva (VAZ-2123), sold today as the Niva Travel, is a different car.

- [ ] **Drive it at 50–70 mph and feel for vibration**
  A shake through the floor at speed is the classic Niva complaint. It usually points to the transfer case's alignment with the propshafts, worn U-joints or dry splines. NIVA-FAQ's centring procedure fixes most of it, but a truck that still shakes may have worn mounts or a bent floor.

- [ ] **Work the transfer-case levers**
  Select low range at a standstill, then lock and unlock the centre diff, and check that the dash light comes on. A centre lock that sticks in or won't engage usually needs the steering-wiggle trick from the FAQ below, but it can also point to a neglected transfer case. Owners advise using the levers at least weekly.

- [ ] **Listen at cold start**
  A brief rattle or rumble from the top of the engine on a cold start is the timing chain slapping a worn tensioner or guide. It's a known and fixable problem, but price it in. The 1.6 and 1.7 petrol engines have no timing belt to worry about.

- [ ] **Check the hubs and the rear axle seals**
  On pre-October-2016 trucks, rock each front wheel for bearing play; the bearings need periodic adjustment. Oil on the inside of a rear wheel or on the brake backing plate means a leaking axle seal or bearing, and the brake shoes are probably soaked.

- [ ] **Get the import paperwork**
  US Nivas arrived from Spain, the Netherlands, Estonia, Russia and Canada, according to BaT listings. You want the CBP entry papers, the EPA and DOT forms, and a clean title in your state. Expect a km/h speedometer and Cyrillic gauges on Soviet-market trucks.

- [ ] **Treat the carburettor and fuel system as suspect**
  BaT sellers of imported 1.6s report replacing the fuel tank, sender, carburettor and plug leads after the trucks had sat. Budget for a carb rebuild or replacement and a new tank on any truck that has been parked for years.

YEARS TO KNOW

2018	RECALL	Rosstandart recall of 3,300 Lada 4×4s for possible cracks in the upper steering shaft (29 November)

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Upper steering shaft may crack (Russia)**
  Lada 4×4, 2018 · Rosstandart, 29 November 2018

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **VIN**
  AvtoVAZ's VIN is XTA (manufacturer), six characters for the type and variant (for example 212100 for a VAZ-2121), one character for the model year, and a seven-digit serial. Hagerty's records show XTA212100E… for a 1984 and XTA212100P… for a 1993. AvtoVAZ starts each model year on 1 July. The plastic data plate is on the right-hand body side panel.
- ☐ **2121 or 21213/21214**
  The 1.6 VAZ-2121 has VAZ-2106 horizontal tail lights, a high loading lip, a four-speed and the old VAZ-2106 dashboard. From 1993–94 the 1.7 trucks have vertical tail lights, a tailgate that reaches the bumper, a five-speed and a VAZ-2108-style dash. The VAZ-21219 (1991–94) is a hybrid: the old body with the new 1.7 drivetrain.
- ☐ **Early details**
  Pre-1985 trucks have a chrome grille surround and sill trim, and a red-background front badge. They're rare in good condition and the ones collectors pay for.
- ☐ **Export variants**
  The 21212 is the right-hand-drive UK version (1983–95), the 21211 a 1.3 for high-tax markets, and the 21215 a Peugeot-diesel export model (1999–2007). The Cossack was a UK and importer trim package, not a factory model.
- ☐ **Not a Niva**
  The Chevrolet Niva (VAZ-2123), sold since 2020 as the Lada Niva and then Niva Travel, is a different and newer design. Bronto-built derivatives such as the long Fora (VAZ-212180) carry their own X7G VIN prefix.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/niva/niva/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks